Europe, the United States, Canada, Australia – as the result of its economic development. They saw development as a linear process, and argued that the "backward" or "underdeveloped" countries needed to move forward along the same path to industrialization in order to catch up with the "developed" world.[2]

Dependency theorists, primarily coming from Latin America and influenced by Marxism, challenged this linear view. They argued that the industrialized countries had benefited from their colonial relations with Latin America and Africa, and that they had developed in tandem – but different – ways. The colonies had undergone *dependent development* based on foreign domination of their economies and the production of primary goods for export to the industrializing colonial powers. Dependent development was skewed in a number of ways. Landed elites maintained a near-feudal control in the countryside, profiting from the labor of a large and extremely poor peasantry. Modern urban areas served the needs of a small elite linked to foreign capital. Income was squandered on luxury consumption by this elite, rather than invested in production. Foreign capital controlled key sectors of the economy. Democratic institutions were weak or nonexistent. This meant that foreign capital reigned supreme, and major decisions about the use of the country's resources were made by outsiders, for the benefit of outsiders.[3]

Cuba's economy exhibited many of the characteristics associated with economic dependency. Three-quarters of the country's arable land was used to produce sugar, which accounted for 80 percent of its exports. Forty percent of the farms and 55 percent of the mills were in the hands of U.S. companies. U.S. investors also controlled 90 percent of Cuba's telecommunications and electrical services and half of the country's railroads, as well as significant portions of the banking, cattle, mining, petroleum, and tourist industries.[4] Almost a quarter of those with jobs worked in the sugar industry, and most of these only seasonally. Technical development helped planters reduce the time of the harvest from 10 months at the beginning of the twentieth century to only three